records all instructions, indicated that the Coromandel Express had been cleared to go on the main line. He says it could have been changed to reverse (go into the loop line) after the derailment, hinting at record-tampering after the incident to cover up the sequence of actions that led to the accident. Meanwhile, another erroneous signalling incident surfaced when a damaging letter dated February 9 by the chief operating manager of South Western Railway came to light. He had found "serious flaws" in the electronic interlocking system when a day earlier, the route of dispatch of the Sampark Kranti Express was altered and the train got a signal to move on the wrong line. The alert loco pilot halted the train and averted a possible collision. Per sources, no action was taken on the errant signalling.

Citing that incident, E.A.S Sarma, former Union secretary in the ministries of energy and finance, wrote to the rail minister. "Had the board acted on it on time," he says, "subsequent accidents could perhaps have been avoided.... I feel surprised that the Railways should hastily announce a CBI probe, suggesting the possibility of sabotage, without the railway safety regulator having an opportunity to look into the technical aspects of the accident. To me, it appears to be a move to mislead the public about the larger issues of failure in governance of the Ministry of Railways."

Many Opposition parties clamoured for Vaishnaw's resignation, following in the footsteps of some railway ministers in the past in similar situations. But the minister was clear he would not yield to the demand. He is said to have told his close associates, "I was clear it was not the right thing to do at this moment. I have a moral responsibility to not run away from work but to fight the war. People need me to show the courage to bring the situation back from the brink." Vaishnaw stayed on at the site of the disaster ensuring that those who were injured were treated and the relatives of those who had died were provided assistance in locating them and giving them a decent funeral. The minister also focused on getting the trains running again, staying through the night to ensure this happened within 51 hours, a fast turnaround.

## LESSONS FROM THE CRASH

Whether triggered by man or machine, the incident has exposed a fatal weakness in the safety mechanism of the Indian Railways. On June 5, the railways launched a countrywide safety drill to check the signal communication apparatus. For nearly a decade, the Indian Railways has been deploying the electronic interlocking system across the country, as part of the several steps being taken to make train travel safer. Half of the country's 7,325 stations already have the technology installed in place of the manual interlocks. Simultaneously, anti-collision devices like the Kavach system have been introduced, though not



GROUND REPORT

# HUMANS OF BALASORE

**Locals, disaster management officials and hospitals came together in a commendable effort to ease the suffering of the victims**

*By* **SANGRAM PARHI**

It was around 7 pm on the night of June 2 and Manmath Bhuyan, 48, was relaxing at the home his station master father had built near the Bahanaga Bazar railway station when he heard the loud crashing sounds outside. "I rushed out on hearing the commotion. It was as though a bomb had hit Bahanaga," he says. Bhuyan's mother, Dhirodbala, actually thought a wayward missile from the nearby Chandipur-on-sea testing centre had crashed into their sleepy hamlet. They didn't know it then, but they were in the vicinity of one of India's deadliest train accidents, which left 288 people dead and another 1,200 injured. The Bahanaga locals were the first responders. "It was dark everywhere," recalls Bhuyan. "Mutilated bodies lay all around the tracks. We shifted the injured to a nearby school till the '108' ambulances arrived."

Help came almost immediately as villagers from both sides of the station rushed to the spot. Under the light of cellphone torches, they pulled out people from the mangled coaches. Others fetched bamboo ladders to climb atop the overturned